

How Election Workers Test Voting Machines Before Ballots Are Counted

From: PBS NewsHour Mined: 2026-10-09 5 min read

The **midterm elections** end on Election Day in November, but in many states people are already voting. For the local officials who run elections, the work started even earlier. A PBS NewsHour report visited election offices to show how they get ready.

In Davis County, Utah, workers run stacks of practice **ballots** through the counting machines before a single real ballot is counted. Some of the test **ballots** are filled out wrong on purpose. This is called **logic and accuracy testing**. It checks that the machines count votes correctly and catch mistakes, such as a voter choosing too many candidates.

Utah is one of a few states where most people vote by mail. **County clerk** Brian McKenzie explained the path a mail ballot takes. Every envelope has its own bar code. If a voter needs a new ballot, the old code is canceled, so no one can get more than one. At least two workers pick up returned **ballots**, and the **ballots** are kept under video cameras around the clock.

Each envelope is scanned, stamped with the date and photographed. Workers compare the voter's signature with up to five signatures on file. **Ballots** move in **batches** of 200 and are counted at every step. McKenzie said nothing in the system is **wireless** or connected to the internet.

This year there was a fight in Washington over voting by mail. New Postal Service rules for mail **ballots** were announced at President Trump's direction, but the Supreme Court blocked them last month. McKenzie said voters can adjust to changes when they have enough time, but sudden changes close to an election can cause confusion and doubt.

Word Treasure

midterm elections -- US elections held halfway through a president's four-year term.

ballots -- Papers or forms that voters use to make their choices in an election.

logic and accuracy testing -- Testing voting machines with practice ballots to make sure they count correctly.

County clerk -- A local official who keeps records and, in many places, runs elections.

wireless -- Able to send information through the air without cables, like Wi-Fi.

batches -- Groups of things handled together at one time.

Background you need

In the United States, elections are run by local officials in counties and towns, not by one national office.

Before ballots are counted, election offices test their machines to make sure each vote is read correctly.

Some states let most voters mail in their ballots, so officials use bar codes and signature checks to make sure each voter sends only one ballot.

Midterm elections choose members of Congress and many state and local leaders halfway through a president's term.

Break it down

LEAD: Voting has started, and local officials prepared long before

KEY EVENT: Logic and accuracy testing of counting machines

+ - WHO: Workers led by Davis County clerk Brian McKenzie

+ - WHERE: Davis County, Utah

+ - HOW: Practice ballots, some marked wrong on purpose

PROCESS: Bar codes, two-person pickup, cameras, signature checks, batches of 200

EVIDENCE: Nothing is wireless or connected to the internet

CONTEXT: Supreme Court blocked new mail ballot rules last month

OPEN QUESTION: How do late changes affect voters' trust?

Why it matters

Trust in elections depends on people understanding how votes are checked and counted, and these steps show the safeguards officials use before results are announced.

Test what you remember

1. Where is the election office described in the article?
 - ☐ (A) Bartow County, Georgia
 - ☐ (B) Long Island, New York
 - ☐ (C) Washington, D.C.
 - ☐ (D) Davis County, Utah
2. Why are some practice ballots filled out wrong on purpose?
 - ☐ (A) To save paper
 - ☐ (B) To confuse workers
 - ☐ (C) To train voters
 - ☐ (D) To check that machines catch mistakes
3. How do most people in Utah vote?
 - ☐ (A) In person only
 - ☐ (B) By phone
 - ☐ (C) Online
 - ☐ (D) By mail
4. What happens to the old bar code when a voter needs a new ballot?
 - ☐ (A) It is canceled
 - ☐ (B) It is printed again
 - ☐ (C) It is sent to Washington
 - ☐ (D) Nothing happens
5. How many ballots are in each batch?
 - ☐ (A) 500
 - ☐ (B) 50
 - ☐ (C) 200
 - ☐ (D) 100
6. What did the Supreme Court do last month?
 - ☐ (A) Moved Election Day
 - ☐ (B) Blocked new Postal Service rules for mail ballots
 - ☐ (C) Ended mail voting
 - ☐ (D) Approved new machines

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: D 4: A 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. County clerk Brian McKenzie: Says voters adjust to changes with enough time, but sudden changes close to an election cause confusion and doubt.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):